Supplementary

Owlie

‘Mom,’ Payal yelled in panic. ‘Owlie’s gone!’

‘Where would she have gone, Payal?’ her mother said crossly. ‘She was right there, sleeping in her cage a little while ago.’

‘But she’s not there now. And, Mom, the door to the garden is open!’ That got Payal’s mother running into the room. Sure enough, there was no sign of Owlie.

What was an owl doing in a house, you ask? Well, Payal’s house was home to all kinds of creatures, mainly abandoned animals. People brought lost dogs, injured cats and baby birds that had fallen out of their cages to Payal’s mother. It wasn’t that they had a large farm or even a large house. It’s just that everyone knew that Payal’s mom had a BIG heart! But even in a household used to such unexpected visitors, Owlie’s advent had been memorable. Shefali didi had just turned up one day, carrying a carton.

When Payal’s mother opened the carton, there was the smallest of owlets sitting in one corner, a small ball of brown and grey. Payal’s mother picked her up gently and placed her in her lap, talking to her just as she would to the dogs. She had never handled owls before, so she was very careful not to get pecked. When the owl got used to her, and seemed relaxed enough, Payal’s mother placed her inside a cage. There were always empty cages in Payal’s house – just in case a bird dropped in! The baby owl climbed on the rod and settled herself.

‘Mom, what shall we call her?’ asked Payal, all excited.‘You choose a name’, said her mother, smiling.‘How about Owlie?’ asked Payal. So Owlie it was.The name was settled, but there was a bigger problem. What does one feed an owl?

Owls are hunters. They eat rats and snakes and frogs. And in Payal’s house, they were all vegetarian, even the dogs! Payal’s mother was totally anti-meat. But now that Owlie had come to stay, she had to get over her dislike for meat. That was another reason why that day was memorable. It was the first day that meat was brought to the house! Payal got the number from her friend and called the meat shop to ask them to deliver half a kilogram of minced meat to the house. They put the meat before Owlie.